CAREER GLITCH · SHORT · SIMPLE · NO BORING PARTS

BARBER IN THE AI ERA

Eighty percent of barbers are self-employed — the 'first job' is a chair you rent before you have a single client.

★ TL;DR — NO — entry economics, not AI. BLS puts the barber median at ~$38,200 ($18.37/hr, May 2025) with growth of just +3% — about 2,500 net jobs in a decade, hiding under the combined group's rosier headline. College Scorecard puts barbering graduates' median tax-reported earnings at $17,533 one year out. Scorecard undercounts tips — printed here honestly — but doubling year one still only reaches the median, not the $45K this card used to claim. The roadmap below is the way OUT. ★

THE CAREER GLITCH TAKE

OUR TAKE: NO — NOT IN 2027

MEDIAN ~$38K · TRAINING 6-12 months · AI RISK LOW · CERTIFICATE

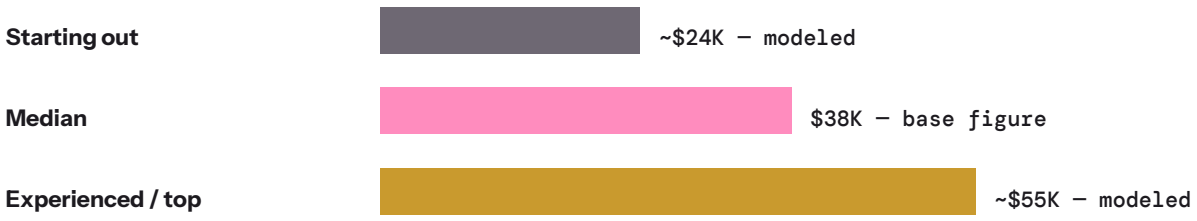
- Fails as a start because: with 80% self-employment there is barely an employer. The standard entry is ~50–60% commission for a new barber, or chair rent around $200–$225 a week — owed before your book exists, alongside tools, insurance and 15.3% self-employment tax.

- The supply pipe is wide open: ~12,398 barbering credentials were counted in the most recent Scorecard year, against 75,800 barber jobs in the entire country growing by roughly 250 a year.

- Still worth money: clipper craft, speed and chair-side loyalty are portable — licensed skin and body work buys the same hands inside occupations with employers, ladders and higher medians.

The site's take, built from this profession's numbers in the Career Glitch base.

THE MONEY — LOOK AT THE BARS



The Career Glitch base figure for Barber is a ~$38K median (compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). The starting and top bars are modeled around that median — orientation, not a promise. Pay swings hard by state, employer and experience: check live postings in your state before planning around any number.

WHAT DOES A BARBER ACTUALLY DO?

- ✓ Cut and fade hair to a standard clients photograph
- ✓ Hot-towel shaves, beard shaping and line-ups
- ✓ Keep blades, clippers and station sanitized between every client
- ✓ Run your book: appointments, walk-ins, rebooking

Think: a craftsman with a chair, a mirror — and rent due every week whether the chair filled or not.

WHAT AI ALREADY TOOK (AND WHAT IT CAN'T)

THE ROBOT	THE HUMAN
Scheduling, reminders, payments and shop marketing automate cleanly, and platforms rent you discovery: Booksy Boost takes 30% of a marketplace-sourced client's first visit, and your reviews stay inside their ecosystem. Style-preview images help the consultation talk.	Clipper control on a real scalp, blend judgment in real light, conversation that makes the shop a habit. Robotic haircutting does not exist in any deployed, credible form — nobody is coming for the craft. What's broken is the beginner's pay, not the work.

⚠ **Scorecard's $17,533 undercounts tips and some self-employment income — the industry says so, and it's true. Do the honest version anyway: double it, and you get roughly the occupation median (~$38,200), not a living built in year one and nowhere near $45K. And don't let the card borrow the combined group's '+7% growth' headline: the barber line itself is +3%, with walk-in chains pricing basic cuts at $15–$28 and capping your first rung.**

THE VIBE — IS THIS YOUR LIFE?

THE JOB IS	THE JOB IS NOT

✓ Craft pride — a clean fade is visible proof ✓ Shop culture and regulars who book by name ✓ A two-week repeat cycle built into human biology	✗ Rent and tax owed in weeks nobody books ✗ Saturdays are not yours ✗ Price-capped basic work is most of a beginner's book

Good fit? You already cut half your neighbourhood for free, have months of runway, and are launching a micro-business on purpose.
Bad fit? You need school to convert into steady wages this year — this trade mostly doesn't have wages.

THE FORK — PICK ONE DOOR

DOOR A — PIVOT TO Esthetician	DOOR B — PIVOT TO Massage Therapist
The licensed beauty seat with a ladder over it: BLS median $45,330 (Skincare Specialists), growth +9%, ~14,200 openings a year, and a 90th percentile of $82,050 where master/advanced tiers gate device work and physician offices pay a ~$51,600 median. Precision, sanitation and regular-building are the same muscles. First move: a 600–750-hour esthetics programme, then W-2 med-spa or physician-office work — an employer fills your book while you build one.	A healthcare licence with the batch's widest door: BLS median $58,450, growth +15%, ~20,400 openings a year, chains hiring at zero experience, top decile $100,200. The route is a 500–1,000-hour programme plus the MBLEx in most states. First move: compare programmes by supervised clinic hours — then let an employer's schedule, not chair rent, carry your first year.

Smart move: The chair-rent model rewards a book you don't have yet. Choose the seat where an employer hands you clients while you build one.
Where you land after: You land where the same hands earn a skin-care or healthcare median — with an employer filling your schedule while your own following grows.

YOUR ROADMAP — 6 STEPS

1	2	3	4	5	6
DO THE	PRICE THE	PICK YOUR	CONVERT THE	ENROLL AND	KEEP BARBERING

STEP 1 — Do the Scorecard math

FREE · TODAY

- Barbering graduates: $17,533 median tax-reported earnings at year 1, $20,210 at year 4
- Note the tip undercount honestly — then note that doubling it still doesn't reach $45K

STEP 2 — Price the chair

WEEK 1

- Chair rent ~$200–$225/wk plus tools, insurance and 15.3% SE tax — before client one
- Chains price basic cuts at $15–$28; that caps what a beginner's book can charge

STEP 3 — Pick your door

WEEK 2

- Door A keeps the craft counter: esthetics, licensed, tiered, employer-filled books
- Door B keeps the hands-on care: massage therapy, +15% growth, chain hiring at 0 years

STEP 4 — Convert the craft

WEEKS 2-4

- Precision, sanitation and regular-building transfer whole into esthetics and massage
- Your portfolio of cuts is proof of hand skill and client manner — bring it

STEP 5 — Enroll and train

WEEKS 3-8

- Esthetics 600–750 hrs, or massage 500–1,000 hrs plus the MBLEx — chosen by clinic hours
- Both end in a licence an employer actually hires against

STEP 6 — Keep barbering priced honestly

ONGOING

- With a book and a runway, a chair is a business; without them, it's rent
- The licence isn't expiring — enter when the math works

FIRST 90 DAYS — JUST DO THIS

□ Today: put $17,533 (Scorecard year 1) next to $38,200 (BLS median) and the $45K this card claimed.

□ Days 1–30: chair-rent math done; door chosen; programmes compared by clinic hours and pass rates.

□ Days 31–60: enrolled; supervised clinic clients under your hands.

□ Days 61–90: clinic hours building; target employers mapped for graduation.

□ Day 90: you're on a licensed ladder with a median above the barber chair's — fade skills still in your pocket.

NEXT — MAKE IT PERSONAL

This roadmap is the same for everyone. Your life is not.

- Not sure this career fits YOU? Take the Big Career Test — 50 questions, your top-3 matches and one honest “probably NOT you”. → careerglitch.com/#test

· Already sure? Turn AI into Your Personal Career Mentor — a 2,300-word system that interviews you first, checks your hours, budget and deadline honestly, and builds YOUR plan into a Notion dashboard. → careerglitch.com/#prompt

★ A CHAIR IS RENT. A LADDER PAYS. ★

CAREER GLITCH · Figures: Career Glitch profession base (medians and training ranges compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). Modeled bars are estimates around the base median. License and certification rules vary by state — verify with your state board before paying for any program.